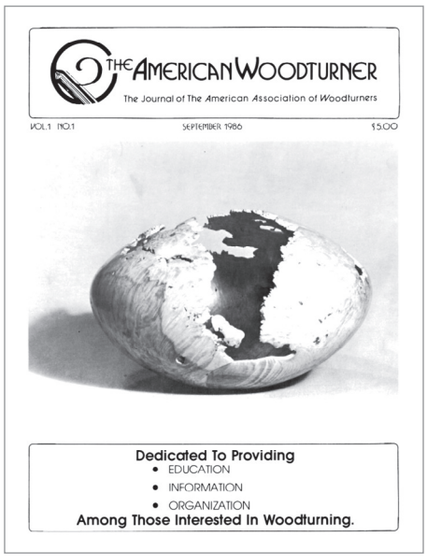
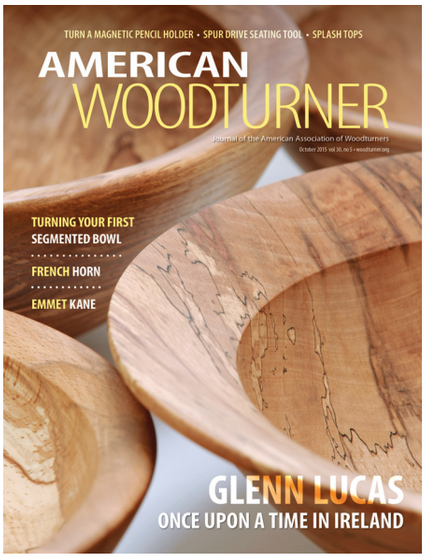
Leafing through the AW journal

Even the AW journal, over the years has also undergone quite a transformation from its beginning in 1986 as a stapled newsletter. It then progressed to a colour cover and then evolved to become a full-colour, professionally produced, top-quality quarterly magazine that went bimonthly in 2010 (Kelsey, p. 174).

Pitfalls aside, the worldwide influence of the AAW has been significant. The heroes of the AAW are also international turning celebrities; the annual trek to the big symposium has become a rite of passage for many international turners, while others all over the world wait for the latest issue of *American Woodturner* so they can catch up on what is happening in the biggest turning club in the world. Turning groups across the globe have emulated the AAW and a delegate from the United States would feel right at home at symposiums as far afield as Germany, New Zealand, Ireland, and South Africa (Martin, p. 37).



September 1986: The first issue of the *American Woodturner* journal. It had 28 black-and-white pages and sported five photos



2015: Today, the *American Woodturner* journal contains more than 70 full-colour pages of instructional material, feature stories, process articles, artist retrospectives, and profiles of innovative turners, and received a 2015 Nichee Award for Best Niche Consumer Association Magazine

A new age for US woodturning

Since the formation of the American Association of Woodturners in 1986, a new tradition of woodturning has developed with a lengthy list of its own attributes (Kelsey, p. 124–125):

- It is process-oriented and, by definition, reveres the single media of wood.
- It is enamoured by faceplate work, rather than spindles and has set the thin-walled vessel as the standard reference for skill.
- It accepts speed-of-production as the common denominator of skill rather than quality, sophistication or repeatability.
- It has little concern for utility/function.
- Although many turners first saw a lathe in industrial arts class or were self-taught, today turning is most often taught in intimate small-group settings.
- It can claim only a few formal college or university programs in higher education and has steadfastly eschewed formal education in art or design.
- In the rush to be 'modern', turners have exhibited little knowledge of, or interest in, historical precedents.
- It was, until the early 1990s, composed almost entirely of middle-aged to elderly Caucasian American right-handed males.
- It has been seen by many practitioners as a hobby or entertainment, often centred upon the size and number of machines, tools and gadgets.
- It is involved with one-of a kind production, even when made for retail sale.
- It sees itself as apart from, and not a subset of, the field of furniture.
- It has an extraordinary sense of community and unique level of sharing and has led the other crafts in its exploration of artistic collaboration.

The AAW today

The AAW attributes its success to the combined enthusiasm, commitment and diligence of the woodturning community including hobbyists, professionals, galleries, collectors and others. Every year since 1992, the AAW has recognised outstanding contributors and has awarded the distinction of Honorary Lifetime Member to a select individual or organisation that has made a significant impact on the field of woodturning. AAW Honorary Lifetime Members include: David Ellsworth, Ed 'Bud' Jacobson, Dale L. Nish, Rude Osolnik, Melvin Lindquist, Ed Moulthrop, Bob Stocksdale, Palmer Sharpless, Alan Stirt, S. Gary Roberts, Alan Lacer, Robyn Horn, Ray Key, Nick Cook, Bonnie Klein, Dick Gerard, Arthur and Jane Mason, Mary Lacer, Jerry Glaser, Arrowmont School of Arts and Crafts, Albert LeCoff, Giles Gilson, Mark Lindquist, John Hill, John Jordan, David Wahl, Allen Hockenbery, and Ruth and David Waterbury. While some of these special people are no longer with us, their passion and extraordinary contributions to the field and AAW endure.

Today, the AAW has more than 15,000 members and more than 350 local chapters worldwide. The association is well known among turning communities globally with more than 1,450 of its members residing in 51 countries outside the US. AAW maintains an office along with its Gallery of Wood Art in Saint Paul, Minnesota. The AAW has evolved into the world's leading resource for woodturning information, inspiration, and instruction. In addition to AAW's annual international symposium and the *American Woodturner* journal, members have access to publications including *Woodturning Fundamentals*, *Safety for Woodturners*, and mentoring publications, as well as a variety of complementary services, website tools grant opportunities, and specialty programming. Learn more about the AAW at www.woodturner.org.

The AAW's 30th annual international symposium will be held at the Atlanta Convention Center at AmericasMart, Atlanta, Georgia, 9–12 June, 2016. Regardless of your skill level or interests, the AAW symposium will offer something for you. You'll be able to select from a broad range of demonstrations and panel discussions to focus on session that will enhance your woodturning experience the most. You'll take away knowledge, tips and techniques sure to enhance your woodturning experience. Learn more about AAW's 2016 symposium at http://tiny.cc/AAW2016Atlanta

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